



THE MOM TEST

How to Talk to Customers & Learn If Your Business is a Good Idea When Everyone is Lying to You

Rob Fitzpatrick



The Big “So What”

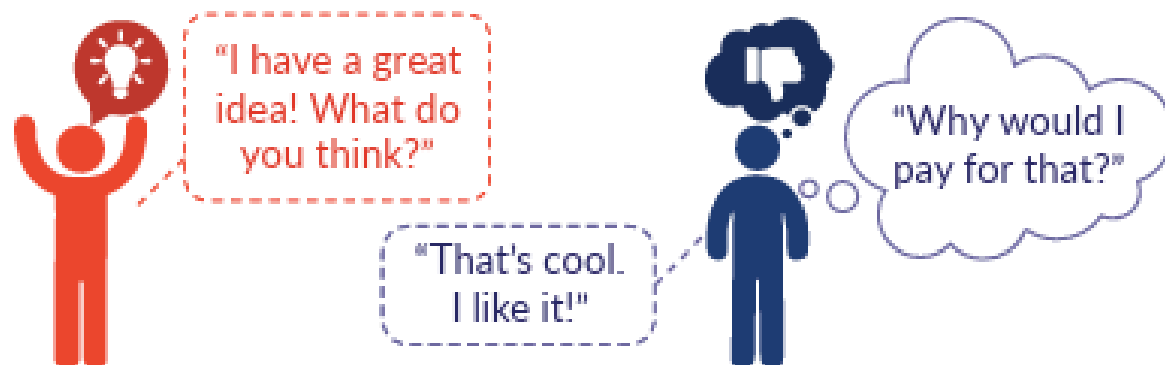
Most startups fail because they build something that nobody wants. The biggest trap? Asking bad questions that lead to misleading answers. *The Mom Test* is a guide for talking to customers in a way that reveals the truth—so you can build something people will actually buy.



Why Customer Conversations Go Wrong

It's important to talk to customers to understand their needs. Yet, most entrepreneurs get it wrong.

- They ask family, friends, or prospects if their business idea is good. But *people lie* because they want to be polite and supportive, especially when they see how passionate you are. This leads to false validation, sending the startup down a wrong path and wasting valuable time and resources.



Rob Fitzpatrick, a tech entrepreneur, learned this the hard way after years of building startups and mentoring founders. In this book, he explains how to get real, actionable insights using The Mom Test—a set of rules to help you uncover what your customers truly need and will pay for, and avoid the pitfall of building something no one wants.

KEY QUOTES

“Trying to learn from customer conversations is like excavating a delicate archaeological site. The truth is down there somewhere, but it’s fragile.”

“Questions are our tools. But we must learn to wield them. It’s delicate work. And well worth learning.”

“Doing it wrong is worse than doing nothing at all... collecting a fistful of false positives is like convincing a drunk he’s sober: not an improvement.”

“I learned that there’s a big gap between textbooks and check books.”

- The method integrates proven insights from design thinking, lean startup, sales, customer development, and user experience, validated by the author's real-world experience. They are useful for anyone launching a startup, validating a business idea, or improving an existing product.
- In this summary, we present the insights in 2 parts:
 - (i) What is The Mom Test?
 - (ii) How to apply The Mom Test effectively.



The Mom Test: The Art of Asking Good Questions

 The Mom Test has **3 simple rules** for asking the right questions so even your mom can't give you misleading answers.

- Talk about their life, not your idea.
 - Instead of asking, "Do you like this idea?", ask "How do you currently solve this problem?"
- Ask about specifics in the past, not hypotheticals about the future.
 - Instead of asking, "Would you pay for this?", ask "The last time you faced this problem, what did you do?"
- Listen more, talk less. The more you talk about your idea, the more you bias their response. To learn what matters to customers, let them do the talking.

 If possible, ask about their problems without mentioning your solution—if they don't know your idea, they can't give false validation. So, **what questions should you ask or avoid?**

- Do get specific facts about customers' lives—problems, behaviors, goals, and constraints.
 - *Pain points*: What's the hardest part about dealing with this issue?
 - *Current solutions*: How are you solving this today?
 - *Past behavior*: When was the last time you faced this problem? What did you do?

KEY QUOTES

"I can't teach you how to make your business huge... But I can give you the tools to talk to customers, navigate the noise, and learn what they really want."

"The Mom Test is a set of simple rules for crafting good questions that even your mom can't lie to you about."

"The more you're talking, the worse you're doing."

"The measure of usefulness of an early customer conversation is whether it gives us concrete facts about our customers' lives and world views."

- *Spending habits*: Have you ever paid to solve this problem? How much did you pay?
- Don't ask about the solution you should build, including:
 - *Their opinions*: Do you think this is a good idea?
 - *Hypotheticals*: Would you use this if it existed?
 - *Leading questions*: Don't you think this feature is cool?
 - *Fishing for approval*: We're working on this—do you like it?



Managing Misleading Responses



Watch out for **3 types of bad data** which can lead startups to chase false signals, build the wrong product, and waste time/money. Learn to identify and correct them, to keep your customer conversations on track.



Compliments are empty validations. When people say they “like” your idea, it doesn't mean they will use it or pay for it.

- Beware of vague, positive comments like “Great idea!” or “I love it!” These have:
 - (i) No mention of specific pain points, frustrations, or past behaviors; and
 - (ii) No signs of real engagement, such as asking for details, discussing how they'd use it, or committing to next steps (e.g. asking for a demo or offering to make an introduction).
- Deflect compliments and redirect the conversation to facts. If they say, “That sounds great,” clarify with “What makes you say that? Have you struggled with this problem before?”



Fluff refers to vague, hypothetical, or overly-optimistic claims about what someone might do in the future. People are bad at predicting their own behavior, so don't trust such hypothetical statements.

- Listen out for 3 warning signs:
 - (i) Generalized claims like “I never”, “I always”, or “I usually”;
 - (ii) Future-oriented promises like “I will” or “I would”; and
 - (iii) Hypotheticals like “I could”, or “I might”.

KEY QUOTES

“It boils down to this: you aren't allowed to tell them what their problem is, and in return, they aren't allowed to tell you what to build. They own the problem, you own the solution.”

“Bad data gives us false negatives (thinking the idea is dead when it's not) and—more dangerously—false positives (convincing yourself you're right when you're not).”

“Compliments are the fool's gold of customer learning: shiny, distracting, and entirely worthless.”

“You want facts and commitments, not compliments.”

- Dig deeper into specifics and past behavior.
 - (i) If they say "I usually...", ask for specifics, e.g. "Can you walk me through the last time you faced this issue?"
 - (ii) If they say "I would pay for that," follow up with, "Have you ever paid for a similar solution before?"



Wishlists: Customers love suggesting features and improvements, but these may not reflect what they truly need. Blindly following such requests can lead to bloated products and wasted resources.

- Beware of broad suggestions without specific pain points or struggles, e.g. "You should add this feature", "It would be great if it could also do X" or "I think it should be more like product Y".
- Listen for emotions (e.g. frustration, excitement) that suggest it's a real problem for them, and dig deeper to uncover the real issue they're trying to solve.
 - People describe symptoms, but it's your job to diagnose the underlying problem and design the best solution for it.
 - Ask: Why do you want this feature? What problem would it solve for you? How are you handling this issue today? Tell me why this is so terrible for you.
- Ideally, observe what they do rather than trust what they say. If possible, ask them to perform a task that they struggle with, so you can see the issue first-hand.



If possible don't even mention your idea, so you can **focus the conversation on them.**

- If they ask about your product, promise to share more later and redirect the conversation back to their needs.
- If you accidentally start pitching, apologize and refocus on them : "Oops, I got carried away. Let's return to what you were saying earlier about..."
- When they share about a problem, resist the urge to correct them or start offering solutions. Listen to understand their real frustrations.

KEY QUOTES

"Reject their generic claims, incidental complaints, and fluffy promises. Instead, anchor them toward the life they already lead and the actions they're already taking."

"Ideas and feature requests should be understood, but not obeyed."

"Digging into a signal is basically just giving them permission to do a brain dump."

"When you hear a request, it's your job to understand the motivations which led to it."

"Once you start talking about your idea, they stop talking about their problems."



Asking The Right Questions

★ If a question won't change your business, then it's not worth asking. Focus on **tough, important questions** that help you make better business decisions.

- Focus on confirming or debunking critical assumptions that can make or break the business. Ask yourself:
 - (i) What can cause your business to fail?
 - (ii) What must be true for your business to be wildly successful?
- For example, if your startup has legal ambiguities, talk to a lawyer before scaling up. Don't avoid tough questions.

✖ **Embrace bad news.** The sooner you realize you're on a wrong path, the faster you can pivot.

- If you have \$50k capital and spend \$5k to learn you're off-track, you still have \$45k to pivot. But if you spend all \$50k before realizing nobody wants your product, there's no turning back.
- If you only receive good news, then you're not learning anything useful. Negative and lukewarm responses signal low interest—investigate them to challenge your business assumptions.

🔍 Don't **zoom in too early on a specific problem**, such as asking "What's your biggest problem with going to the gym?" before verifying if they even care about fitness.

- Just because someone has a problem doesn't mean they care enough to solve it. Ask broad questions initially, e.g. "What are your biggest challenges right now?"
- Only zoom in when a problem is mentioned unprompted in multiple conversations. Look for strong, recurring signals that it's a must-solve-now problem, not a nice-to-have improvement.
 - Look for people who get emotional about the problem. Someone who says "That's annoying" is unlikely to be a good lead. But if someone says, "This is ruining my life! I'd pay you right now to fix it!" it sends a much stronger signal.

KEY QUOTES

"Every time you talk to someone, you should be asking a question which has the potential to completely destroy your currently imagined business."

"You should be terrified of at least one of the questions you're asking in every conversation."

"You're searching for the truth, not trying to be right. And you want to do it as quickly and cheaply as possible."

"There's more reliable information in a 'meh' than a 'Wow!' You can't build a business on a lukewarm response."

"Most people have lots of problems which they don't actually care enough about to fix, but which they'll happily tell you the details of if you ask them."



Address both **market and product risks**. An idea is worthless if no one wants it (market risk), or if you can't execute it (product risk).

- Make sure you address both critical factors for business success:
 - (i) Market risk: Do customers want this? Will they pay? Are there enough customers?
 - (ii) Product risk: Can you build it? Can you scale it?
- Identify and remove your biggest risks first.
 - (i) If your idea faces market risk, validate demand first.
 - (ii) If your idea has product risk, test feasibility before scaling.
- If your business has more product risk than market risk, then you can't rely on conversations alone. You need other techniques like rapid prototyping to mitigate technical risks.



Processes & Tips for Early Customer Conversations

Now, let's explore the strategies and processes to apply The Mom Test for effective customer feedback.



Define a Strong, Specific Niche



Beware of 3 traps that lead you to talk to the wrong people.

- Targeting too broad a segment: Don't try to target everyone, as it dilutes your focus and leads to conflicting insights.
 - For example, "students" is too broad—it includes PhD students, prep-school kids, homeschooled kids, rural students, and city college students, all with different needs, budgets, and behaviors. A specific segment could be "final-year students preparing for job interviews."
 - If you don't see consistent patterns in problems and goals, it's a sign that you must drill down to a more specific niche.

KEY QUOTES

"It's tempting to obsess over the most interesting of several failure points and ignore the others. It's a great way to miss important questions."

"When the feedback is all over the map, it's really hard to extract value. Once you get specific, you can learn."

- Missing key customer segments. For example, if you're building an app for students, you can't target students alone. You should also consider parents, schools, and administrators.
- Neglecting stakeholders in a complex buying purchase. If you're selling to public schools, you also need buy-in from teachers, principals, school boards, and even taxpayers. If your product relies on partners or distributors, do consider their constraints. Talk to decision-makers, influencers, and end users to get a fuller picture.



A **good niche** is one that needs a solution urgently, will pay for it, and is easy to reach. When you're launching a startup or new product, it helps you to focus on the right customers first.

- Big companies all started small. For example, Google initially helped PhD students to find obscure code, while Evernote helped moms to save recipes.
- Who: Start with a broad group, then use customer slicing to narrow down your target segment.
 - (i) Within this group, who wants it most?
 - (ii) What's their real motivation (problem or goal)?
 - (iii) Are there other groups with the same motivation?
- Where: identify behaviors and where they gather:
 - (i) What are these people already doing to solve this problem?
 - (ii) Where can we find them (e.g. online communities, events, professional groups)?
- A good segment = who + where. If you can't clearly define both, it means you must refine your segment further.



Move Through Discovery Conversations Quickly



According to Steve Blank's Customer Development model, we should hold **3 distinct types of conversations** for: (i) understanding the customers and their problem, (ii) presenting a solution, and (iii) selling the product. This prevents early customer discovery from being biased by pre-conceived solutions.

KEY QUOTES

"You can't get the data you need if you're talking to the wrong people."

"When it comes to avoiding drowning and making faster progress, good customer segmentation is your best friend."

"Before we can serve everyone, we have to serve someone."

"Good customer segments are a who-where pair. If you don't know where to go to find your customers, keep slicing your segment into smaller pieces until you do."

"A customer segment isn't very useful if there's no way you can get in touch!"

"The structure of separate problem/solution/sales conversations is critical for avoiding bias, but it's important to realise that the first one doesn't actually need to be a meeting."

- However, you don't need formal meetings to get valuable insights. Quick, casual chats often work better because:
 - (i) Formal meetings are time-consuming: a 1-hour meeting often takes >4 hours including prep, commute, and follow-up.
 - (ii) Early-stage founders may struggle to secure meetings since they lack credibility.
 - (iii) Formal meetings can set the wrong expectations. Customers assume they'll be pitched a product, leading to polite but biased responses.



Casual conversations can give faster insights and less biased responses than formal meetings.

- Rather than spend weeks trying to schedule meetings, just ask about people's problems in casual settings whenever the opportunity arises.
- The goal in early-stage customer learning is to validate if a problem exists and if customers care enough to solve it. You can gather valuable insights in 5-15 min by asking good questions without pitching your solution. For example:
 - At conferences: "I'm curious: how did you land this speaking gig?"
 - At networking events: "What tools do you currently use for X?"
 - Over coffee: "What's the hardest part about managing your team?"
- Longer discussions (30–60 min) might be needed later when you investigate workflows or industry dynamics. Still, keep these casual to increase the likelihood of honest, unbiased feedback.
 - For example, Fitzpatrick once assumed that investors struggled with too many startup leads. Instead of pitching a solution outright, he opened a meeting with a casual question: "You must get tons of leads—how do you handle them?" The investor replied that their analysts filter out most leads, leaving them with only 10 serious ones

KEY QUOTES

"Learning about a customer and their problems works better as a quick and casual chat than a long, formal meeting."

"You can talk anywhere and save yourself the formal meetings until you have something concrete to show."

"If it feels like they're doing you a favour by talking to you, it's probably too formal."

"Give as little information as possible about your idea while still nudging the discussion in a useful direction."

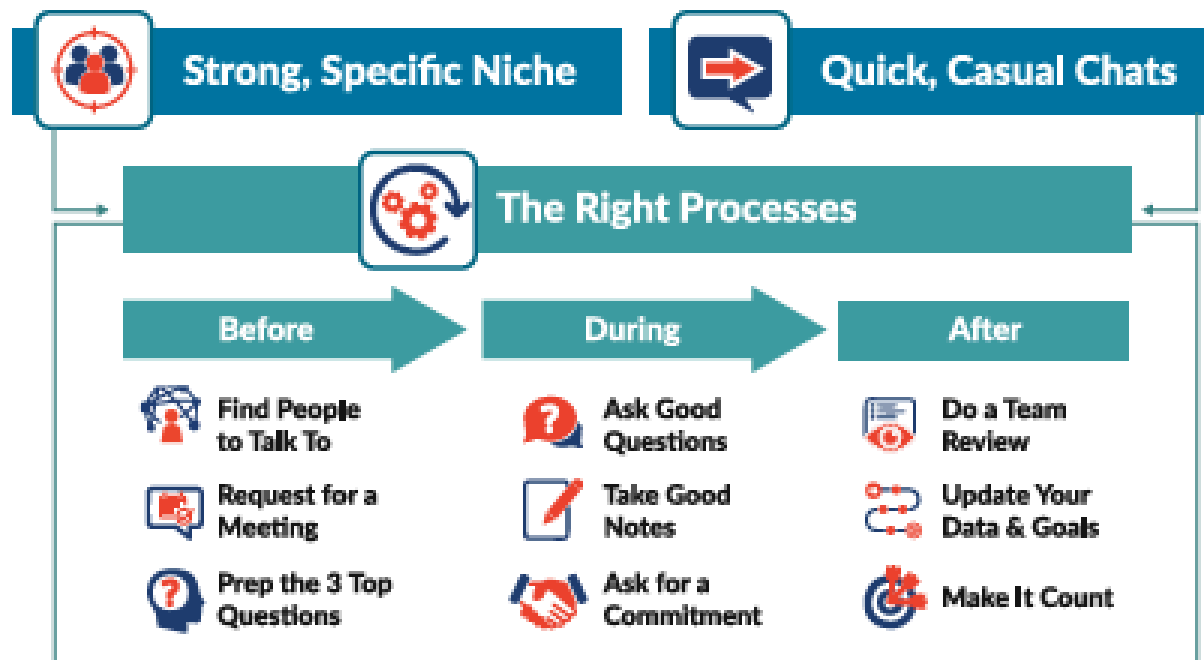
to track. Within 5 min, Fitzpatrick had established that the problem didn't exist.



Adopt the Right Processes



Treat customer conversations not as isolated events, but part of a **structured learning process**. Make sure the insights are gathered effectively, shared throughout the team, and acted upon.



- Beforehand, you must find people to talk to and prepare your questions in advance.
- During meetings, ask good questions, take good notes, and secure an advancement.
- After each conversation, review results with the team, and update your database/goals.



First, **find the right people to talk to**. If you have customers, start by talking to them. If not, you'll need to seek out conversations.

- Nurture prospects over time for warm introductions.
 - (i) *Cold calls and messages* have a high rejection rate. But even 1-2 "yeses" out of 100 contacts could open new doors.
 - (ii) Spark *spontaneous, casual conversations* in daily interactions. People love talking about their challenges—you simply need to ask good question, show genuine interest, and listen.

KEY QUOTES

"The customer and learning has to be shared with the entire founding team, promptly and faithfully."

"Having a process is valuable, but don't get stuck in it. Sometimes you can just pick up the phone and hack through the knot."

"The only thing people love talking about more than themselves is their problems."

KEY QUOTES

"If it's a topic you both care about, find an excuse to talk about it. Your idea never needs to enter the equation and you'll both enjoy the chat."

"Blogging about an industry is... a good exercise to get your thoughts in a row. It makes you a better customer conversationalist."

"The world is a relatively small place. Everyone knows someone. We just have to remember to ask."

(iii) Use *landing pages* to collect emails of people who're interested in your product, then reach out to start a conversation.

- You can also bring prospects to you:

(i) Host *meetups or events*, e.g. "happy hour for designers". Or, let's say you want to connect with top universities but lack credibility—try hosting an online "knowledge exchange" between department heads of elite schools and invite other universities to listen in. This builds credibility and gives you instant access to high-value contacts.

(ii) *Speak or teach* through workshops, online videos, or free consulting hours to build credibility and relationships.

(iii) Use *blogging* to build an audience, credibility, and organize your thoughts to communicate more clearly.

- Ask for introductions through mutual contacts.

(i) Tap on direct/indirect contacts in your network. A group of graduates got 3 introductions just by standing up in a coworking space and asking, "Does anyone know someone at McKinsey? We'll buy you a beer!"

(ii) Reach out to industry advisors (for industry contacts), investors (for B-to-B contacts), or university professors.

(iii) Call in favors from people who invited you to keep them in the loop in past meetings. Say something like, "Hey, we're finally ready to talk to [desired contact]. Would you be open to making an intro?"



Ask for meetings the right way. Set the right expectations so people don't assume you're pitching a product.

- Use this 5-part meeting request formula:

(i) Vision: Share the industry problem you're solving, without mentioning your solution.

(ii) Framing: Say you're still learning and have nothing to sell.

(iii) Weakness: Show you need their help.

(iv) Pedestal: Show why they're the right person to help.

(v) Ask: Request a chat.

- Meet in person where possible. It's harder to assess body language in phone/video calls, or to build relationships for future introductions.
- Don't approach customer conversations with a sales mindset, as it creates a needy vibe and weakens your position. Shift your mindset—you're just looking for advisors who could get excited about your idea and share valuable insights. This will make your conversations more casual and natural.



Prepare your 3 biggest learning questions for every conversation.

- Consider the biggest risks and questions based on the type of person you're speaking with. If you're meeting a potential customer, then ask about pain points, options, and purchasing habits. If you're meeting an investor, ask about market size, risks, or revenue potential.
- Involve the entire team (including members from product development and sales/marketing).
- List down what you think the customer wants, and do desk research so you don't waste time asking for answers you can find online.



During the meeting, ask the right questions, manage misleading information, and keep it casual. It's also crucial to **take good notes**.

- If possible, have 2 people attend the meeting, so 1 person can lead the conversation while the other takes notes.
- Fitzpatrick recommends writing your notes using tools like Google Docs or Evernote, so it's easy to reorganize them later.
- Record important points including:
 - (i) ⚡ Pain points or problems;
 - (ii) 🎯 Goals or job-to-be-done;
 - (iii) 🚧 Obstacles in their way;

KEY QUOTES

"Phone calls end up sounding more like scripted interviews than natural conversations, because they are. It's a constraint of the medium."

"You are just trying to find helpful, knowledgeable people who are excited about your idea."

"If you don't know what you're trying to learn, you shouldn't bother having the conversation."

"Taking good notes is the best way to keep your team (and investors and advisors) in the loop. Plus, notes make it harder to lie to yourself."

"Ask learning questions which pass The Mom Test. Then confirm by selling it. This happens over both the life of your company and during a single meeting."

(iv) 🔄 Current workarounds; and

(v) 📄 Context (or background).

- Use symbols and emojis to capture the context and emotional reactions quickly. Star ★ any follow up actions required.
- Capture exact quotes in quotation marks, especially about pain points or constraints.



Never close a meeting without **asking for a commitment**.

- A meeting is only successful if there's an advancement, i.e. they make a commitment that moves them closer to a purchase. A commitment involves giving up something valuable, such as:

(i) *Time*: Committing time for further discussions/demos.

(ii) *Reputation*: Introducing you to a decision-marker or vouching for you publicly.

(iii) *Money*: Pre-ordering, paying a deposit, or signing a letter of intent.

The more they give up, the stronger their interest.

- After gathering insights using the Mom Test, confirm if they're truly interested by giving them a chance to commit or to reject you.
 - If they say, "That sounds interesting," ask: "Would you be open to introduce me to the person in charge of this?"
 - If they hesitate, it's a red flag that they might not really care about the problem. This is still useful information, as it helps you to cut through the noise and focus only on those who're truly interested.



Right after a meeting, **review the notes** with your team to ensure nothing gets lost in translation.

- Share the main takeaways, including the key quotes, insights, and problems encountered.
- Consider what worked and what can be improved in future conversations.

KEY QUOTES

"A meeting has succeeded when it ends with a commitment to advance to the next step."

"By giving them a clear chance to either commit or reject us, we get out of the friend-zone and can identify the real leads."

"It's not a real lead until you've given them a concrete chance to reject you."

"In early stage sales, the real goal is learning. Revenue is just a side-effect."

"If you don't know why you're there, it becomes a sales meeting by default."

- Regularly update your customer knowledge base and learning goals: What insights have emerged? What else must we learn?



If you're going to invest time/resources to talk to customers, then **make it count**.

- Ensure you reap the rewards by (i) focusing on questions that truly matter, and (ii) sharing the learning throughout the team.
- Your goal is to have just enough meetings to extract key insights and move forward. So, talk to people until you stop hearing new info. If your niche is well-defined, this might take just 3-5 conversations. But, if you're still getting confused signals after more than 10 meetings, then you probably need to narrow or refine your target segment.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

Using the tips above, you can systematically gather insights that lead to sound business decisions. The book also includes many real-world examples, detailed scripts for different scenarios, and practical refinements to improve customer conversations over time. For more details, visit www.momtestbook.com.



About the Author



Rob Fitzpatrick is a serial entrepreneur, startup mentor, and author. He spent over a decade working in startups, sales, and product development, and has advised thousands of founders on how to validate their ideas without misleading feedback. He currently runs workshops, writes extensively about startup best practices, and builds tools to support founders in making smarter business decisions.

KEY QUOTES

"Talking to customers is a tool, not an obligation."

"You can't outsource or hire someone to do customer learning."